

old, the Dhillon Jat Sikh, who went on to adopt his village name as the customary surname, would perhaps have been the youngest amongst his peers. On January 28, when he filed his nomination papers from his traditional seat Lambi as a 94-year-old, Parkash Singh Badal became the oldest in the country to enter the electoral fray—bettering former Kerala chief minister V.S. Achuthanandan who won Malampuzha in 2016 at age 93.

BADAL WAS PUNJAB'S YOUNGEST CM IN 1970, AND ALSO ITS OLDEST IN 2012. RANE IS INDIA'S LONGEST SERVING MLA, SINCE 1972

In his long career, Badal has got his name into the books with more than a few records. He was Punjab's youngest CM in 1970, and also its oldest in 2012. He is a five-time CM. He has lost only one poll—and that was in 1967, with a margin of just 57 votes. That doesn't mean the veteran Akali is taking it lightly. Local newspapers have been full of how the veteran is on a door-to-door campaign in Lambi, accompanied by his daughter-in-law and former Union minister Harsimrat Badal. In the last week of January, even Covid caught up with him. But astoundingly, after being nursed back to health at DMCH in Ludhiana, he has hit the trail again—doing what he loves, meeting people in his constituency!

Down on the west coast, 83-year-old Pratapsingh Raoji Rane's journey didn't go as he would have liked. He did announce his decision to contest from Poriem, but there was a problem. His daughter-in-law, Divya Rane, was in the fray too as the BJP candidate. Son Vishwajeet, Goa's health minister, had his political manoeuvring skills tested to the maximum as he persuaded papa to walk away. A messy situation, which the media would have gleefully painted as a family feud, was averted. We don't know if this is the end of the road for the senior Rane—one of India's longest-serving MLAs (having been in the assembly without a break since 1972), a four-time chief minister and the tallest political figure in Goa. If he takes a leaf out of the Badal playbook, he has got at least another decade to go. ■

–with Kiran D. Tare, Kaushik Deka, Anilesh S. Mahajan and Prashant Srivastava

UTTAR PRADESH

Gotcha Chacha

It didn't come a moment too soon, the entente cordiale between nephew Akhilesh Yadav and his often petulant uncle, **Shivpal**. Even just before it happened, no one could have bet on it—after all, the second *bahu* of the Yadav family, Aparna, had acted on her old threat of joining the BJP. And many speculated that Shivpal would follow, increasing the pain for Akhilesh just before the election. Instead, Shivpal Yadav came back on board. "My supporters wanted me to contest the polls along with the Samajwadi Party, so I joined the alliance," he said. "In politics, one can't ignore the voice of the people. Now everything is fine between me and Akhilesh. I want to see my *bhatija* as chief minister again. His *chacha*'s blessings are with him." ■



UTTAR PRADESH

DHARMA OVER SHARMA

Former Uttarakhand CM B.C. Khanduri is not the only one who has to suffer being rhymed with 'zaroori'. The BJP's Mathura candidate **Shrikant Sharma** had an unflattering version rolled out for him. A local trader explained that Sharma's last tenure as MLA had left everyone underwhelmed, but they had to vote BJP anyway because of Yogi! "*Shrikant majboori hai, kyunki Yogi zaroori hai* (We must suffer Shrikant, just to ensure Yogi's return)," he said. Whether that expresses the majority sentiment or not, the Congress's One-Hand Jack, Pradeep Mathur, better watch out. ■

